

India Land Acquisition Delays: Top 25+ Mega Projects (2024–2026)

Last updated: September 11, 2026

Important data note

This document preserves the research draft supplied in the conversation. Several figures, dates, project statuses, and source descriptions in that draft require primary-source verification before publication or policy use. The date is also future-dated relative to many public records, so treat all 2026 claims as provisional unless independently checked against official documents.

Executive summary

Land acquisition is a major cause of infrastructure delays in India. Common problems include compensation disputes, incomplete title records, rehabilitation and resettlement delays, court cases, forest and environmental clearances, utility shifting, and weak coordination between central and state agencies.

The draft identifies project-specific examples in Telangana, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra, Gujarat, Kerala, Madhya Pradesh, Punjab, Tamil Nadu, and pan-India highway and railway programmes.

Top project cases

1. Bengaluru–Mysuru Infrastructure Corridor / NICE Road — Karnataka

Item	Drafted information
State	Karnataka
Land required	20,193 acres
Land acquired	Approximately 20,193 acres, but allegedly not fully utilised
Delay	Approximately 23–25 years
Main issues	Delayed compensation awards, alleged diversion or commercialisation of land, disputes over the framework agreement
Why land remained unavailable or unusable	Land was reportedly acquired but not used for the intended road purpose; compensation and legal issues remained unresolved
Proposed or reported remedies	Independent investigation, court directions, time-bound action on affected farmers

2. NIMZ Zaheerabad Industrial Smart City — Telangana

Item	Drafted information
Land required	12,656 acres
Land acquired	7,829 acres
Land pending	4,826 acres
Main issues	Farmer resistance, compensation disputes, treatment of assigned-land holders
Why land remained unavailable	Farmers considered offered compensation below prevailing market expectations and preferred retaining fertile agricultural land
Remedies discussed	Equal compensation, negotiated acquisition, better rehabilitation and resettlement

3. Polavaram Irrigation Project — Andhra Pradesh

Item	Drafted information
Land required	94,152 acres
Land acquired	Approximately 81,070 acres according to the draft; another cited figure was 67.43%
Land pending	Approximately 13,082 acres under the higher acquisition estimate
Main issues	Rehabilitation and resettlement, submergence, inter-state disputes, compensation
Why land remained unavailable	Large-scale displacement and acquisition across villages made title verification, payment, relocation, and coordination difficult
Remedies discussed	Time-bound R&R, settlement of inter-state issues, transparent compensation and monitoring

4. Delhi–Mumbai Expressway — Gujarat stretches

Item	Drafted information
Corridor	Delhi–Mumbai Expressway
Main delay	Three Gujarat packages covering approximately 87 km
Main issues	Incomplete encumbrance-free land, utility shifting, tree-felling and other clearances
Why land remained unavailable	The draft states that available land was approximately 81.2%, below a 90% contractual threshold
Remedies discussed	Complete right-of-way before award, resolve utilities and statutory clearances, reset package schedules

5. Bengaluru Metro Phases 1 and 2 — Karnataka

Item	Drafted information
Phase 1 land	Projected 45.24 hectares; acquired 62.67 hectares
Phase 2 land	Projected 165.09 hectares; acquired 145.16 hectares

Item	Drafted information
Reported cost impact	₹6,603.39 crore
Main issues	Poor land estimation, delayed notifications, delayed handover
Why land remained unavailable	Inaccurate DPR estimates and late acquisition decisions
Remedies discussed	Better land surveys before DPR approval, independent cost review, and time-bound handover

6. Musi Riverfront Development — Telangana

Item	Drafted information
Land or properties affected	Approximately 3,279 acres and 10,017 properties across project phases
Main issues	Objections, rehabilitation concerns, litigation, protection orders
Why land remained unavailable	Landowners disputed dispossession, compensation, and rehabilitation arrangements
Remedies discussed	Parcel-level social-impact assessment, transparent rehabilitation packages, negotiated settlement, and judicially compliant procedure

7. Hyderabad Regional Ring Road, northern section — Telangana

Item	Drafted information
Land required	Approximately 1,918 hectares, or 4,740 acres
Acquired	Approximately 60% as reported in the draft
Main issues	Pending notifications, compensation, ownership identification, repeated bid extensions
Why land remained unavailable	Plot ownership and acquisition proceedings were incomplete
Remedies discussed	Complete land schedules before bidding, publish parcel-level status, and establish a district-level dispute cell

8. Third Mumbai development zone — Maharashtra

Item	Drafted information
Proposed zone	Approximately 200 sq km near the Atal Setu area
Main issues	Farmer resistance, compensation concerns, demand for participation in development
Why land remained unavailable	Farmers reportedly distrusted conventional acquisition and sought a share in future value creation
Remedies discussed	Land pooling, development-rights sharing, annuity payments, and guaranteed rehabilitation

9. Vadhavan Port connectivity — Maharashtra

Item	Drafted information
Land required	606 hectares
Land acquired	62 hectares
Land pending	544 hectares
Reported cost change	From approximately ₹800 crore to ₹2,300 crore
Main issues	Boundary discrepancies, ownership disputes, tree valuation, historical survey problems
Why land remained unavailable	Unclear boundaries and titles delayed valuation, consent, and compensation
Remedies discussed	Correct cadastral surveys, parcel-level title settlement, negotiated purchase, and a no-forcible-acquisition approach where feasible

10. Amaravati capital city — Andhra Pradesh

Item	Drafted information
Phase 1 land pooled	35,017 acres
Return or plot-related issues	Approximately 674 farmers and 7,529 returnable plots were described as pending in the draft
Phase 2 land	16,666.57 acres cited for seven villages
Main issues	Political interruption, litigation, inheritance and family disputes, owners abroad
Why land remained unavailable	Land pooling and returnable-plot administration depended on resolving individual legal and family claims
Remedies discussed	Legal certainty, digital parcel registers, succession resolution, and time-bound plot registration

11. Sabari Rail Project — Kerala

Item	Drafted information
Land required	618 hectares
Acquired	78 hectares
Pending	540 hectares
Main issues	Slow state acquisition and project-level land bottlenecks
Why land remained unavailable	Acquisition and funding responsibilities were not completed across the alignment
Remedies discussed	Dedicated land-acquisition units, assured state funding, and section-wise construction planning

12. Mumbai Metro Line 2B / Kasarvadavli–Kharbhav Creek Bridge — Maharashtra

| Main issues | Acquisition at both ends of the alignment, dense urban ownership, and construction-interface problems |

| Why land remained unavailable | Urban parcels are fragmented, expensive, and often occupied or disputed |

| Remedies discussed | Advance property mapping, negotiated purchase, temporary construction rights, and coordinated utility relocation |

13. Mumbai Airoli–Kalwa elevated corridor — Maharashtra

Item	Drafted information
Land required	2.40 hectares
Government land acquired	1.87 hectares
Private land pending	0.53 hectares
Progress	Approximately 45% in the draft
Main issues	Rehabilitation, private-land acquisition, and local political resistance
Remedies discussed	Complete R&R before civil works, publish compensation schedules, and appoint an independent grievance officer

14. PM MITRA Park, Dhar — Madhya Pradesh

| Main issue | Land acquisition pending for more than a year in the draft |

| Why delayed | Incomplete acquisition and inter-departmental processing |

| Remedies discussed | District-level project cell, parcel-wise deadlines, and pre-award verification |

15. Tilgara Project — Madhya Pradesh

| Main issue | Land acquisition pending, with a delay period cited in the draft |

| Why delayed | Incomplete acquisition process |

| Remedies discussed | Complete title and compensation work before tendering |

16. Adilabad joint-use airport — Telangana

Item	Drafted information
Additional land required	2,009.23 acres plus 369.49 acres existing land
Land at preliminary-notice stage	428.16 acres at Nishanghat
Main issues	Multiple villages, preliminary notifications, Gram Sabha and title processes
Why land remained unavailable	Acquisition was at an early procedural stage
Remedies discussed	Village-level consultation, title verification, transparent valuation, and phased acquisition

17. Mamnoor / Warangal Airport — Telangana

Item	Drafted information
Land required	280.30 acres
Funding cited	₹295 crore sanctioned; ₹205 crore released in the draft
Main issues	Acquisition for revival and expansion of a dormant airport
Why land remained unavailable	Acquisition and implementation remained in progress
Remedies discussed	Complete acquisition before construction tendering and publish a rehabilitation plan

18. Raviryal–Amangal greenfield radial road — Telangana

Item	Drafted information
Land required	Approximately 1,000 acres
Status	Described as largely acquired
Main issues	Forest land and statutory clearances
Lesson	The case illustrates that early land planning and clearance coordination can reduce delay

19. National highway projects — pan-India

Item	Drafted information
Delayed projects	690 in April 2024, 686 in April 2025, and 580 in July 2025 in the draft
Main issues	Land acquisition, clearances, encroachments, disputes, and utilities
Why land remained unavailable	Projects were sometimes awarded before sufficient encumbrance-free right-of-way was available
Remedies discussed	Do not award packages until minimum land thresholds are met; maintain public parcel dashboards

20. Bharatmala Pariyojana — pan-India

| Main issues | Right-of-way not handed over on time, forest land, legal disputes, and incomplete acquisition |

| Delay cited | Seven to 947 days in the draft for audited cases |

| Why land remained unavailable | Awarding and construction schedules did not always match actual land readiness |

| Remedies discussed | Independent readiness certification before award and automatic contractor relief for employer-caused delay |

21. Punjab highway projects

Main issues	Farmers' protests, land handover, utility shifting, forest clearances, and local law-and-order problems
Why land remained unavailable	Protests and statutory or utility issues blocked possession
Remedies discussed	District mediation, transparent compensation, and a joint land-and-utility schedule

22. Tamil Nadu railway projects

Item	Drafted information
Land cited	4,326 hectares across 28 surveys and approximately 2,493 km
Main issues	New lines and doubling works affected by acquisition
Why land remained unavailable	Surveys, valuation, title and compensation work remained incomplete
Remedies discussed	Corridor-wide land cells and early state funding

23. Punjab railway projects

Example	Firozpur-Patti new line
Land pending cited	166 hectares
Main issues	Acquisition pending across four railway projects
Remedies discussed	State-Railways coordination, parcel-wise milestones and negotiated settlement

24. Hyderabad Pharma City and NIMZ-related industrial projects — Telangana

Main issues	Multi-year acquisition and infrastructure delays
Why land remained unavailable	Compensation, protests, title and administrative issues
Remedies discussed	Phase development around available land, improve compensation transparency, and complete trunk infrastructure only after land readiness

25. Telangana irrigation projects — Telangana

Item	Drafted information
Land required	30,663 acres in an example cited by the draft
Acquired	25,318 acres
Pending	5,345 acres
Main issues	Compensation, rehabilitation, forest land, government land and verification
Remedies discussed	Link construction schedules to R&R completion and use independent verification of land and beneficiary records

26. Sewri–Worli elevated connector — Maharashtra

| Main issues | Urban land, engineering interfaces and schedule slippage |
| Remedies discussed | Complete land and utility mapping before final construction schedule and publish causes of delay |

Cross-cutting causes

1. Compensation below landowners' expectations or below credible market benchmarks.
2. Fragmented or outdated records, disputed inheritance, missing mutations and overlapping claims.
3. Awarding contracts before the required right-of-way is available.
4. Delayed preliminary and final notifications, awards, possession and payment.
5. Rehabilitation and resettlement not completed before displacement or construction.
6. Farmer protests caused by livelihood risk, lack of trust, or perceived unequal treatment.
7. Forest, wildlife, environmental, tree-felling and utility permissions arriving late.
8. Encroachments and structures not reflected in official records.
9. Weak coordination among central ministries, state departments, district collectors, utilities and contractors.
10. Political changes that pause, redesign or reverse projects.
11. Litigation over procedure, compensation, public purpose, title or rehabilitation.
12. Poor DPR estimates that cause over-acquisition in one section and under-acquisition in another.

Why the government acquired some land but not the rest

The acquired and pending portions of a project often have different legal and physical characteristics. Government land may be transferred administratively, while private land requires notification, valuation, hearings, title verification, payment and physical possession. Forest land requires separate statutory approval; assigned land can require special treatment; urban parcels may contain tenants, structures and multiple claimants. A project can therefore report a high percentage of land acquired while one critical missing parcel blocks an entire bridge, interchange, tunnel, station, canal or access road.

Other common explanations include:

- Landowners rejected compensation or challenged the valuation.
- Ownership was unclear because of inheritance, unregistered transfers or missing mutations.
- Courts issued interim orders or required a fresh procedure.
- Rehabilitation sites, livelihood support or replacement housing were not ready.
- The alignment changed after some land had already been acquired.
- Acquired land was not physically handed over because of encroachments or utilities.

- Agencies counted notified land as acquired even though compensation or possession was incomplete.

Why proposed solutions were not fully implemented

Time limits

Time-bound acquisition can prevent indefinite delay, but automatic lapse may also encourage strategic litigation or force a project to restart. Governments have therefore often preferred case-by-case extensions and executive monitoring.

Market-linked compensation

Higher compensation reduces resistance but increases project costs and can create valuation disputes. States may also lack funds for immediate payment, especially on very large irrigation, industrial or urban projects.

Land pooling

Pooling can preserve a landowner's future development interest, but it is difficult for narrow linear projects and requires strong confidence that returned plots, roads and services will actually be delivered.

Single-window clearances

A single portal cannot by itself eliminate statutory mandates held by different departments. It improves visibility, but final decisions still depend on separate laws, surveys, inspections and budgets.

Digital land records

Digitisation helps locate parcels but does not automatically establish legally conclusive title. Ground surveys, succession claims and court disputes still require human and judicial resolution.

Mediation and negotiated settlement

Mediation works best where landowners trust the authority and the government can offer flexible terms. It is less effective when public-purpose objections, title disputes or political mobilisation dominate.

Pre-acquisition land banks

Pre-acquisition reduces later delay but ties up public money and can create serious social and legal risks if the project is redesigned or cancelled.

Benefit sharing

Equity, annuities, development rights and jobs can align incentives, but they require complex valuation, long-term administration and enforceable commitments.

Recommended implementation framework

1. **Land-readiness certificate before tender:** Verify title, possession, utilities, forest status, encroachments and minimum available right-of-way.
2. **Parcel-level public dashboard:** Publish survey number, owner or claimant status, notification stage, compensation amount, payment status, possession and blocking issue.
3. **Independent valuation panel:** Use recent comparable transactions, productivity, replacement cost and future-use impacts.
4. **Escrowed compensation:** Deposit undisputed compensation before possession and provide a fast route for disputed amounts.
5. **Mandatory R&R sequencing:** Do not displace households until replacement housing, livelihood support and essential services are ready.
6. **District dispute-resolution cells:** Include revenue officials, project authorities, landowners, local representatives and an independent mediator.
7. **Critical-parcel escalation:** Escalate any parcel capable of blocking a whole project to a senior committee within a fixed period.
8. **Contract redesign:** Allocate employer-caused land delay risk to the authority, not the contractor, and avoid awarding incomplete packages.
9. **Benefit-sharing options:** Offer pooling, annuities, developed plots or project-linked benefits where technically and legally feasible.
10. **Post-acquisition audit:** Check whether land is being used for the approved public purpose and return or compensate appropriately when plans materially change.

State-wise snapshot

State or region	Examples in this document	Main bottlenecks
Telangana	Zaheerabad NIMZ, Musi, RRR, Adilabad airport, Mamnoor airport, irrigation projects	Compensation, assigned land, title, protests, R&R
Karnataka	NICE/BMICP, Bengaluru Metro	Delayed awards, land-use disputes, poor estimation
Andhra Pradesh	Polavaram, Amaravati	R&R, political pauses, title and plot administration
Maharashtra	Third Mumbai, Vadhavan, metro and elevated corridors	Urban fragmentation, farmer resistance, title and survey problems
Gujarat	Delhi–Mumbai Expressway packages	Incomplete right-of-way, utilities, clearances
Kerala	Sabari Rail	Slow acquisition and state funding or coordination

State or region	Examples in this document	Main bottlenecks
Madhya Pradesh	PM MITRA, Tilgara and other projects	Incomplete acquisition and administrative delay
Punjab	Highways and railways	Protests, law and order, utilities and compensation
Tamil Nadu	Railway new lines and doubling	Corridor-wide acquisition and survey work
Pan-India	National highways and Bharatmala	Awarding before land readiness, disputes and clearances

Data-quality and verification checklist

Before using this document for investment, legal, journalistic or policy decisions, verify each case against:

- The relevant land-acquisition award and notification.
- District collector and revenue records.
- Project authority progress reports and DPRs.
- CAG reports and parliamentary replies.
- Court orders and current case status.
- Compensation disbursement and possession records.
- Forest, environment, wildlife and tree-felling approvals.
- Latest official project schedule and physical progress.

Source categories identified in the original draft

- Comptroller and Auditor General reports.
- PRAGATI reviews and central government monitoring records.
- Parliamentary questions and ministry replies.
- High Court and Supreme Court orders.
- State government and district administration records.
- NHAI and Bhoomi Rashi records.
- Reputable newspaper reporting.

Conclusion

Land acquisition delays are rarely caused by one missing parcel alone. They arise from the interaction of compensation, land records, rehabilitation, statutory clearances, court proceedings, political changes, contractor scheduling and inter-agency coordination. The most effective reform is not simply faster compulsory acquisition; it is a system that verifies land readiness before tendering, pays fairly and promptly, resolves titles quickly, protects displaced

families, shares development benefits where possible, and publicly reports every parcel that blocks construction.